GAMING

Mastercard denies pressuring game platforms, Valve tells a different story

IMAGE CREDITS: ROBERTO MACHADO NOA/LIGHTROCKET / GETTY IMAGES

Anthony Ha — 2:29 PM PDT · August 3, 2025

The outcry after a recent marketplace crackdown on games with adult content, seemingly due to pressure from payment processors, prompted Mastercard to release a brief statement Friday pushing back against recent headlines.

"Mastercard has not evaluated any game or required restrictions of any activity on game creator sites and platforms, contrary to media reports and allegations," the company said, adding, "At the same time, we require merchants to have appropriate controls to ensure Mastercard cards cannot be used for unlawful purchases, including illegal adult content."

This follows an open letter by the advocacy group Collective Shout addressed to executives at PayPal, Mastercard, Visa, and other companies, criticizing them for allowing the sale of "No Mercy" and other games that depict rape, incest, and child sexual abuse.

In the following weeks, Steam announced that it would ban games that violate the rules of its "payment processors and related card networks and banks." Then Itch.io said it was removing games with adult content from its browse and search pages while conducting a broader audit.

While Mastercard's statement seems to undermine the narrative that payment and card companies were the ones pressuring the game marketplaces,

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Steam owner Valve responded with a statement of its own, provided to PC Gamer and other gaming sites.

According to Valve, “Mastercard did not communicate with Valve directly, despite our request to do so. Mastercard communicated with payment processors and their acquiring banks. Payment processors communicated this with Valve, and we replied by outlining Steam’s policy since 2018 of attempting to distribute games that are legal for distribution.”

Valve said its response was “rejected” by the payment processors, who noted the “risk to the Mastercard brand” and pointed to a Mastercard rule against “illegal or brand-damaging transactions.”

Meanwhile, Itch.io said that it’s now re-indexing free games with adult content while negotiating with payment processors, including Stripe, which

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for its part said it's "unable to support sexually explicit content" due to "banking partners."

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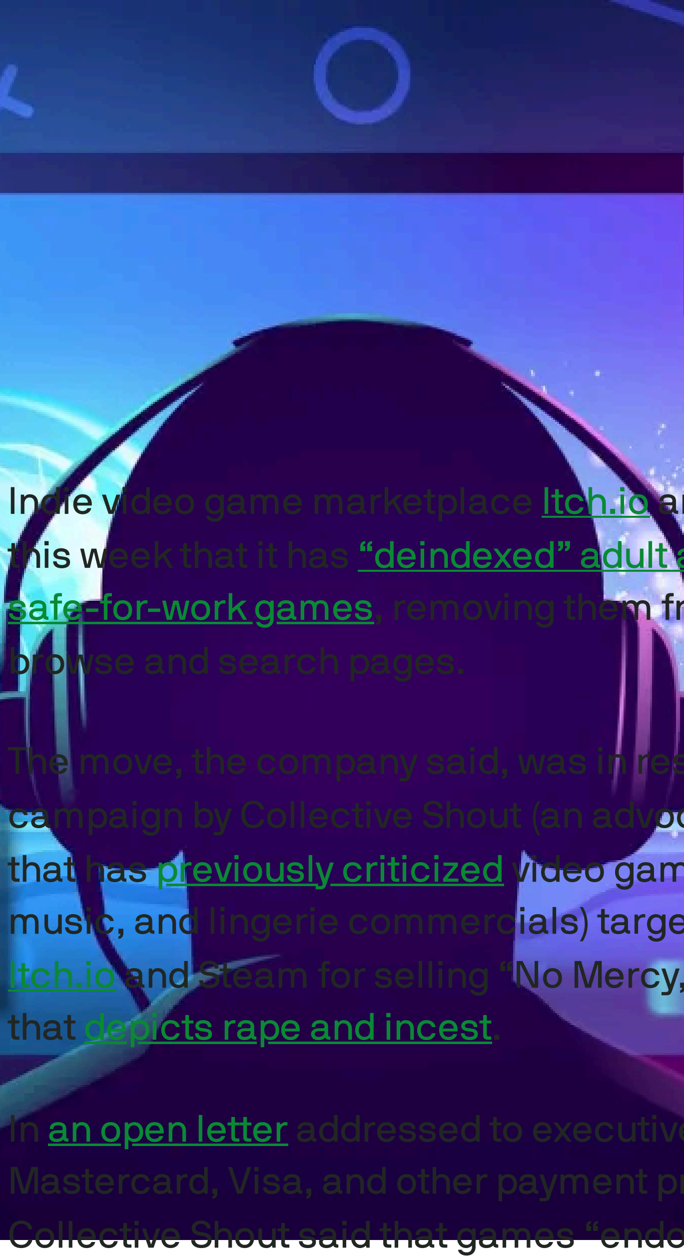
Itch.io is the latest marketplace to crack down on adult games



Anthony Ha — 11:12 AM PDT · July 27, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: HASE-HOCH-2 / GETTY IMAGES

Indie video game marketplace Itch.io announced this week that it has "deindexed" adult and not-safe-for-work games, removing them from its browse and search pages.

The move, the company said, was in response to a campaign by Collective Shout (an advocacy group that has previously criticized video games, rap music, and lingerie commercials) targeting both Itch.io and Steam for selling "No Mercy," a game that depicts rape and incest.

In an open letter addressed to executives at PayPal, Mastercard, Visa, and other payment processors, Collective Shout said that games "endorsing men's sexualised abuse and torture of women and girls fly in the face of efforts to address violence against women."

"We do not see how facilitating payment transactions and deriving financial benefit from these violent and unethical games, is consistent with your corporate values and mission statements," the organization added.

The campaign appears to have worked, with Steam saying earlier this month that it would ban games that "may violate the rules and standards set forth by Steam's payment processors and related card networks and banks, or internet network providers."

Similarly, Itch.io said, "To ensure that we can continue to operate and provide a marketplace for all developers, we must prioritize our relationship with our payment partners and take immediate steps towards compliance."

It also said that "No Mercy" had been "temporarily available on itch.io before being banned back in April," and that "the situation developed rapidly," forcing the company to "act urgently to protect the platform's core payment infrastructure," without providing advanced notice to creators.

The company said it's now conducting a "comprehensive audit" to ensure that games available on the marketplace meet "the requirements of our payment processors," with adult content remaining deindexed until the audit is complete. After the audit, Itch.io said NSFW game creators will be required to confirm that their content is allowed under the policies of their payment processors linked to their account.

On social media, users criticizing Itch.io's decision noted that its current terms declare that adult content violations are “permanent with no chance of appeal” and that any funds in an offending account “will not be eligible for payout” — or as one developer put it, “If you violate the rules, we take all your money. Not just the money from that work, ALL your money from EVERYTHING you’ve ever made.”

This is far from the first time that payment companies appear to have pressured online platforms over adult content — for example, last year Gumroad pointed to restrictions from payment processors when it implemented stricter rules around NSFW art, and OnlyFans also blamed “banking partners and payment providers” when it banned explicit content (a decision that it subsequently reversed).

A Change.org petition with more than 137,000 verified signatures criticizes Mastercard and Visa for their role in these types of decisions. Among other things, the petition demands that the payment companies “stop censoring legal fictional content that complies with the law and platform standards” and “reject influence from activist groups that promote moral panic or misrepresent fiction as harm.”

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PayPal partners with MasterCard for store payments

Sarah Perez — 7:12 AM PDT · September 6, 2016

PayPal this morning announced an expanded partnership with MasterCard aimed at helping the payments service become a more universally accepted checkout method at stores. The partnership, which follows a similar deal with Visa earlier this year, will make MasterCard a clear payment option within PayPal, increase PayPal's presence at point-of-sale, and will enable Masterpass (MasterCard's digital wallet) as a payment option for PayPal's Braintree merchants.

In July, PayPal buried the hatchet with Visa as well, in a deal that makes PayPal an option when people pay in stores with their smartphone. The partnership also helped PayPal's Venmo service, as its users could now instantly withdraw money when they linked their Venmo account to their Visa debit cards. MasterCard cardholders will now have a similar ability to make instant transfers on Venmo, via MasterCard Send.

With MasterCard now on board with PayPal, the goal is to help PayPal establish more traction at point-of-sale, where it's facing increased competition from tap-and-pay rivals like Apple Pay, and to a lesser extent, Android Pay and Samsung Pay. Some stores have also implemented their own digital payments service, like Starbucks, Walmart, and more recently, CVS.

PayPal says it will increase its presence at stores by allowing customers to use their tokenized MasterCard in their PayPal Wallet to make in-store purchases at more than 5 million merchants around the world where contactless payments are supported.

In addition, under the expanded partnership between PayPal and MasterCard, consumers and small businesses will be able to instantly cash out funds held in their PayPal account to a MasterCard account. PayPal will also receive certain financial volume incentives, as it did with Visa, and MasterCard will no longer charge PayPal the digital wallet operator fee.

Where before PayPal encouraged customers to link

earlier deal with Visa, Visa Checkout was separately announced today as also coming to Braintree.)

The two companies expanded a prior relationship, too, by agreeing to a multi-year extension of the PayPal Business Debit MasterCard program in the U.S., which follows a deal to extend the PayPal Extras MasterCard co-branded credit card program.

While an important strategic move for PayPal in terms of increasing its payments service at point-of-sale and online, where it faces newer rivals like Stripe, making deals with Visa and MasterCard could also impact PayPal's profits in the short-terms. Bank transfers are free, but working with the payment networks means PayPal will be paying fees. These concerns caused PayPal's stock to drop when the Visa deal was announced, but as of this morning the stock was on the rise.

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Aria: Providing Cheaper PCI Compliance for Payment Processors

Contributor

2:46 AM PST · December 17, 2009

Achieving *Payment Card Industry Data Security Standard* (PCI DSS) compliance for online transactions is an expensive and timely endeavor; routinely costing hundreds of thousands of dollars and spanning several quarters in time. According to [Gartner], PCI compliance will cost up to an average of $2.7 million among Level 1 merchants and $267,000 among Level 2 merchants. Further, [Visa] and [Mastercard] will be imposing new PCI requirements upon online merchants, which will include more frequent on and off site security reviews, beginning in 2010; thus forcing more companies to upgrade their systems to meet compliance standards.

Demand billing and recurring subscription management company, Aria, offers a solution built to manage PCI compliance for companies. Instead of companies investing in the necessary infrastructure to meet the compliance standards themselves–which includes employee background checks, installation of security cameras on-premise, and third party audits of your network–they can have Aria handle the entire online transactions process, from start to finish, taking advantage of their level 1 (the highest and most rigorous) compliance level, thus mitigating costs which would be incurred had a company tried to become compliant.

By taking advantage of Aria's suite of payment processors, which include the likes of Authorize.net, Chase Paymentech, Cybersource, PayPal, TransFirst, and RBS Worldpay, customers are able to shop around and find a solution which suits their needs. This versatility adds an extra layer of security and functionality. Conversely, if a company wishes to make themselves PCI compliant, they can only use one payment processor, severely limiting their options.

Aria promises to have their solutions "deployed in 30 days or less for $30,000," but founder and CEO Ed Sullivan says that many times they are able to deliver compliance even sooner. The services offered by Aria are intended for businesses involved in card-not-present transactions and their customer base includes those who are in the cloud, staff, telecommunications, media, and online gaming sectors.

Aria is based in Philadelphia and has a sales and marketing office in San Mateo. A complete list of the payment processors which Aria is affiliated with can be found here.

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Elavon to acquire Sage Pay, a gateway that competes with Stripe, PayPal and Adyen, for $300M

Ingrid Lunden — 1:46 AM PST · November 18, 2019

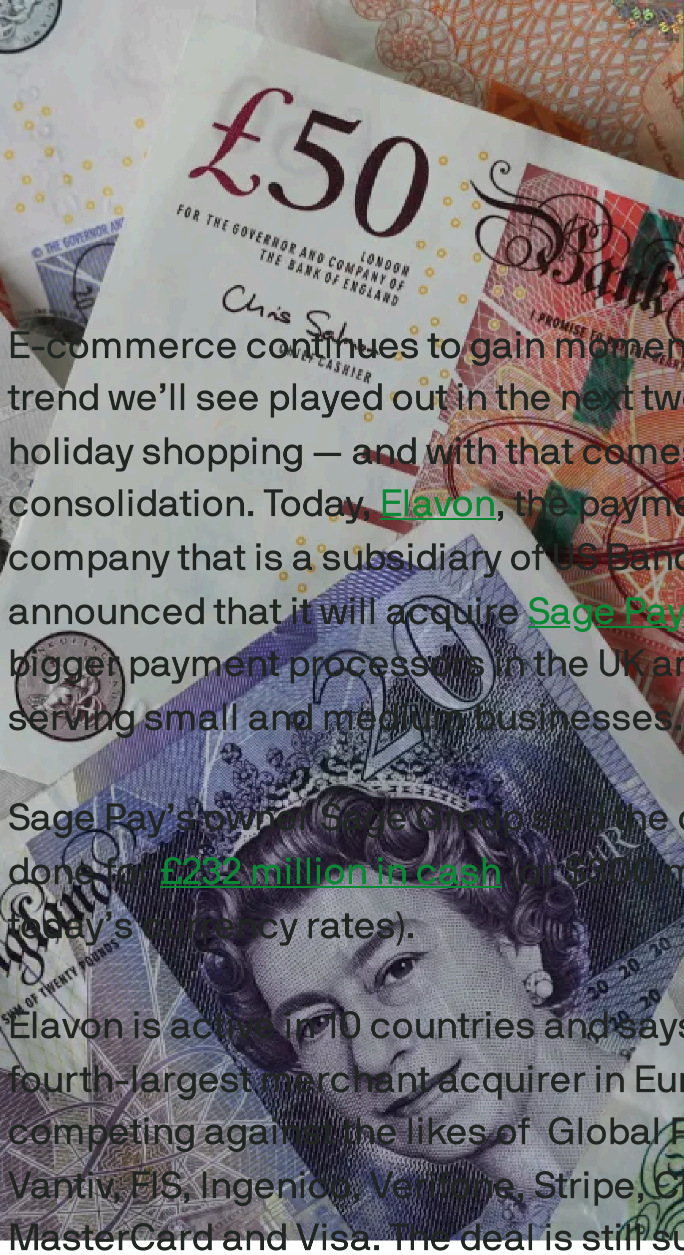

IMAGE CREDITS: CHRIS RATCLIFFE

E-commerce continues to gain momentum — a trend we'll see played out in the next two months of holiday shopping — and with that comes more consolidation. Today, Elavon, the payments company that is a subsidiary of US Bancorp, announced that it will acquire Sage Pay, one of the bigger payment processors in the UK and Ireland serving small and medium businesses.

Sage Pay's owner Sage Group said the deal is being done for £232 million in cash (or $300 million at today's currency rates).

Elavon is active in 10 countries and says it's the fourth-largest merchant acquirer in Europe, competing against the likes of Global Payments, Vantiv, FIS, Ingenico, Verifone, Stripe, Chase, MasterCard and Visa. The deal is still subject to regulatory approval (both by the Federal Reserve in the US and the Central Bank of Ireland), and if all proceeds, the deal is expected to close in Q2 of 2020.

The acquisition points to a bigger trend underway in e-commerce. The market is very fragmented, not just in terms of the companies who sell goods online but also (and perhaps especially) in terms of the companies that manage the complexities at the back end.

In keeping with that, Sage Pay has a lot of competitors in its specific area of taking and managing the payments process for online retailers and others taking transactions online or via mobile apps. They include some of the same competitors as Elavon's: newer entrants like Stripe, Adyen, and PayPal (all of which have extensive businesses covering many countries and are each larger than Sage, valued in the billions rather than hundreds of millions of dollars), but also smaller operations like GoCardless as well as more established companies like WorldPay.

This deal is a mark of the consolidation that's been taking place to gain better economies of scale in a market where individual transactions generally generate incremental revenues.

Sage Pay, in that context, was a relatively small player. It 2018 revenues were £41 million, but it is profitable, with an operating profit of £15 million, and Sage said it expects "to report a statutory profit on disposal of approximately £180 million on completion."

The deal comes on the heels of Sage Group — which is publicly traded — confirming reports in September that it was looking for strategic alternatives for the payments business. Sage Group for the last couple of years has been divesting payments and banking assets to focus more on accounting, people and payroll software, which it sells through an SaaS model.

"Our vision of becoming a great SaaS company for customers and colleagues alike means we will continue to focus on serving small and medium sized customers with subscription software solutions for Accounting & Financials and People & Payroll," said Steve Hare, Sage's CEO, in a statement. "Payments and banking services remain an integral part of Sage's value proposition and we will deliver them through our growing network of partnerships, including Elavon."

Elavon, as the consolidator here, was itself acquired by US Bancorp way back in 2001 for $2.1 billion. Currently it is active in 10 countries, but in that same vein of consolidation to improve economies of scale on the technical side, and to aggregate more incremental transactions on the financial side, Elavon's main objective is to increase its overall share of the e-commerce market in Europe. specifically by expanding with Sage Pay further into the UK and Ireland.

"We are a customer-focused company that is helping businesses succeed in a global marketplace that is changing rapidly," said Hannah Fitzsimons, president and general manager of Elavon Merchant Services, Europe. "This acquisition brings tremendous talent and leading technology to Elavon, which can be leveraged across the European market."

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